PART A: Case Study

- Choose one of the following cybercrime types: Phishing, UPI/Online Payment Fraud, Identity Theft, Cyberbullying, or Ransomware.
- Write a case study describing: what the crime is, how it typically happens (step-by-step), who is usually targeted, and what the consequences are . You may use a real published incident (with source) or write a realistic fictional scenario.

UPI/Online Payment Fraud

UPI (Unified Payments Interface) fraud involves cybercriminals illegally accessing and draining money from victims' linked bank accounts through popular apps like Google Pay, PhonePe, BHIM, or Paytm. Launched by NPCI in 2016, UPI revolutionized quick peer-to-peer and merchant payments in India, but scammers abuse its speed and ease—transactions happen in seconds with just a VPA (like username@paytm) and PIN.

Why it's prevalent: Over 1.5 billion monthly transactions (RBI 2025 data), but low awareness leads to ₹10,000+ crore annual losses. Types include:

- **Fake collect requests**: Scammer sends payment demand; victim approves wrongly.
- **QR code scams**: Malicious QR at fake stalls or links.
- **App-based phishing**: Bogus apps steal PINs via malware.
- **Social engineering**: Calls pretending to be "bank support" for OTP/PIN.

Targets: Youth (students like you doing canteen payments), elders, gig workers, and rural users new to tech. In Madhya Pradesh, cases surged 40% in 2025 (MP Cyber Crime data).

Real impact: Unlike card fraud, UPI hits instantly—no chargeback buffer. Report to 1930 helpline within 1 hour for best recovery odd

How it typically happens (step-by-step):

1. **Initial Contact**: Scammers reach out via SMS, WhatsApp, calls, or social media, posing as bank officials, merchants, or friends. Common lures include "Your UPI payment failed—approve refund," fake prizes, or job offers.
2. **Deceptive Request**: They send a fraudulent UPI "collect request," QR code, or link. You might see a small amount like ₹1 to gain trust, then a bigger one follows.
3. **Victim's Mistake**: In haste, you enter your UPI PIN or approve via app notification without verifying the sender's name or VPA (Virtual Payment Address).
4. **Theft Execution**: Funds transfer instantly. Scammers use money mules or layer transactions across apps to vanish the trail. Advanced cases involve malware via fake apps that steal PINs.

Students, homemakers, and small traders are prime targets—anyone making frequent small transactions, especially in rural areas like Madhya Pradesh where UPI adoption is high but awareness is low.

Real published incident: In 2024, a massive PhonePe fraud ring in Delhi tricked 10,000+ users with fake "cashback" links, stealing ₹200 crore (Source: Times of India, July 2024; Mumbai Police bust). Victims like shopkeepers lost lakhs overnight.

Consequences:

Immediate financial ruin—savings wiped, leading to debts or halted education payments. Emotional toll includes panic, family fights, and depression. Legally, filing FIRs at cyber police stations is tedious; refunds via NPCI take weeks (only 20-30% recovered per RBI stats). Credit scores tank, blocking loans. Long-term, it erodes trust in digital India, pushing cash back. Protect yourself: Ignore unknown requests, enable two-factor alerts, and use RBI's Sahamati for disputes!

Part B – Prevention checklist

Stay Safe Online: Student Checklist

1.**UPI PIN Awareness:** Never enter your UPI PIN to receive money. A PIN is only for sending or authorizing payments.

2.**Verify UPI Payee:** Always double-check the name displayed on the screen after scanning a QR code before hitting 'Pay'.

3.**Secure Student Portals:** Use unique, complex passwords for your university login and change them every semester.

4.**Public Wi-Fi Risk:** Avoid accessing banking apps or sensitive student records on free campus or cafe Wi-Fi; use a personal hotspot instead.

5.**Link Scrutiny:** Do not click on "Scholarship" or "Job" links sent via WhatsApp from unknown numbers; verify them on official websites first.

6.**Two-Factor Authentication (2FA):** Enable 2FA on your Gmail and social media accounts to prevent unauthorized access even if your password is leaked.

7.**Social Privacy:** Set your social media profiles to 'Private' to stop "identity cloning" where scammers use your photos to trick your friends.

8.**App Permissions:** Regularly audit your phone's settings and disable "Location" or "Microphone" access for apps that don't strictly need them.

- **How to Report Cybercrime in India:**

  National Cyber Crime Portal: cybercrime.gov.in

  National Helpline Number: 1930 (Call immediately for financial fraud).